

The Emerging Gulf Security Architecture:

The Mecca Defence Alliance (KSA–Turkey–Pakistan) and the Iran Dimension

An Analytical Synthesis of Assessments from US and International Think Tanks

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Abstract

The formalization of the **Mecca Joint Defence Agreement** (formally the **Mecca Defence Alliance**) on August 7, 2026, by the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia (KSA), the Republic of Turkey, and the Islamic Republic of Pakistan marks a structural inflection point in Middle Eastern and South Asian security dynamics. Against the backdrop of protracted regional hostilities and the perceived attenuation of the United States security umbrella, the alliance pools Saudi sovereign capital, Turkish defense-industrial sophistication, and Pakistani conventional military depth under an Article 5–style collective defense commitment. Uniquely, the alliance founders have maintained an explicitly inclusive diplomatic posture, keeping the door open to regional states, including the Islamic Republic of Iran. This briefing paper synthesizes evaluations from premier international and United States strategic think tanks—including the Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS), the Baker Institute for Public Policy, the Center for International Policy (CIP), the Atlantic Council, the Carnegie Endowment, the Royal United Services Institute (RUSI), and Chatham House—examining operational realities, geopolitical hedging, and the strategic paradox of Iranian inclusion.



Figure 1: Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, Saudi Crown Prince and Prime Minister Mohammed bin Salman, and Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif display the concluded agreements at the Mecca Joint Defence Summit in Saudi Arabia (August 2026).

1 Introduction and Strategic Context

The consolidation of the trilateral pact signed at the Mecca Summit by Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif directly succeeds the September 2025 bilateral *Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement* (SMDA) between Riyadh and Islamabad. Analysts across the policy community categorize the catalysts behind this rapid institutionalization into three systemic vectors:

- **Erosion of Credibility in US Guarantees:** Across regional capitals, confidence in Washington’s unconditional security commitments has progressively eroded over more than a decade. Analysts trace this trajectory through several defining inflection points: the non-retaliation following the September 2019 Abqaiq–Khurais attacks on Saudi Aramco infrastructure, the 2021 withdrawal of Patriot missile batteries, and subsequent regional conflagrations across the Gulf and Red Sea chokepoint following October 2023. Regional middle powers increasingly view Washington’s security architecture as unpredictable, politically conditional, and transactional.
- **Shift from Ad-hoc Coalitions to Institutional Treaties:** Previous regional frameworks, such as the 2015 Islamic Military Counter Terrorism Coalition (IMCTC), remained largely consultative and lacked mandatory mutual defense mechanisms. In contrast, the Mecca Defence Alliance introduces an Article 5–style collective security pledge (“an attack on one is an attack on all”), establishes a permanent General Secretariat headquartered in Riyadh, and institutes standing ministerial, political, and military oversight committees.
- **Synergy of Middle-Power Capabilities:** The alliance links complementary national assets:
 1. *Saudi Arabia:* Unrivaled financial liquidity, sovereign investment depth, geo-economic energy primacy, and religious soft power.
 2. *Turkey:* NATO’s second-largest standing military, combat-proven expeditionary doctrine, and a rapidly expanding defense-industrial base (including Baykar Akinci/TB2 UCAVs, MILGEM warships, advanced electronic warfare, and the fifth-generation KAN fighter program).
 3. *Pakistan:* Nuclear capability, battle-hardened conventional armed forces, extensive historical security deployments in the Arabian Peninsula, and established co-development partnerships with non-Western defense suppliers.

2 United States Think Tank Assessments

Leading United States strategic research institutes have scrutinized the Mecca Defence Alliance not merely as a regional pact, but as an acute challenge to Washington’s traditional role as the exclusive security guarantor of the Middle East.

2.1 Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS)

In a landmark analysis produced by the Project on Nuclear Issues (PONI) titled “*Could the Pakistani-Saudi Defense Pact Be the First Step Toward a NATO-Style Alliance?*”, CSIS fellows Diya Ashtakala, Doreen Horschig, and Bailey Schiff evaluated the operational, geopolitical, and non-proliferation ramifications of the burgeoning alliance:

- **Deterrence by Ambiguity vs. Institutional Execution:** CSIS researchers emphasized that while the alliance employs NATO-like rhetoric, it faces formidable hurdles in replicating NATO’s structural credibility:

“While the pact’s NATO-like language signals an intent to strengthen collective deterrence, the SMDA currently lacks the necessary provisions for nuclear deterrence and regional

political consensus to evolve into a joint defense framework... Despite its NATO-style language, it lacks the nuclear and political basis for true collective defense."

However, CSIS concluded that full institutionalization is not necessarily Riyadh's immediate goal. Rather, the pact succeeds in creating *deterrence through strategic ambiguity*—signaling to regional rivals and adversaries that any armed aggression will trigger unpredictable trilateral entanglements.

- **The Proliferation Question and Nuclear Ambiguity:** CSIS warned that the deepening security partnership between Riyadh and Islamabad inevitably heightens scrutiny over Saudi Arabia's nuclear ambitions:

"The long-held 'bomb in the basement' theory—that Saudi Arabia could quickly acquire a nuclear weapon—has gained credibility over time... If Saudi Arabia views relying on Pakistan for a nuclear weapon as a viable shortcut to the bomb, it may abandon possible interests in indigenous development, which requires more time, money, and technical expertise."

CSIS observed that while Pakistan has officially walked back statements suggesting formal extended nuclear deterrence, the conventional deployment of Pakistani troops, air defense assets, and fighter squadrons to Saudi soil creates an implicit security umbrella that complicates adversary planning.

- **Diplomatic Leverage with Washington:** CSIS analysts noted that Riyadh utilizes alternative security pacts as bargaining leverage against the United States. By demonstrating that viable security alternatives exist outside Western structures, Saudi Arabia strengthens its negotiating hand for advanced US defense acquisitions (such as F-35 fighter aircraft) and civil nuclear cooperation without accepting prohibitive non-proliferation restrictions.

2.2 Baker Institute for Public Policy (Rice University)

Dr. Kristian Coates Ulrichsen, Fellow for the Middle East at the Baker Institute, framed the alliance within the long-term structural recalibration of Gulf defense doctrines. Ulrichsen argued that the emergence of the Mecca Alliance is neither an impulsive overreaction nor a direct rupture with the West, but the culmination of a decade of strategic reassessment:

- **Strategic Optionality, Not Outright Replacement:**

"Doubts about the reliability of US security partnerships have developed over more than a decade and have been intensified by recent regional escalations. These new defence agreements are intended to provide regional states with additional strategic options rather than replace the United States."

- **The Logic of Strategic Hedging:** Ulrichsen observed that Gulf policymakers have absorbed the harsh reality of American domestic political polarization. Because US foreign policy can swing radically between administrations, Gulf monarchies can no longer anchor their national survival to the assumption of permanent US military intervention. The Mecca pact represents concrete diversification, constructing autonomous security nodes that function independently of congressional approval or White House vetoes.

2.3 Center for International Policy (CIP)

Sina Toossi, Senior Fellow at the Center for International Policy in Washington, analyzed the geopolitical realignment underpinning the pact, highlighting the breakdown of binary, US-imposed Middle Eastern security frameworks:

- **Rejection of Zero-Sum Containment:** Toossi observed that regional powers are deliberately dismantling Washington's traditional framework of dividing the region into pro-US and anti-US blocs:

“The agreement is a clear indication that regional states are actively reassessing their security arrangements, with Saudi Arabia seeking to expand its network of security partnerships beyond traditional Western dependencies... Regional actors are no longer willing to serve as frontline instruments in an escalatory conflict dictated from abroad.”

- **Tehran’s Rapprochement Strategy:** CIP’s analysis highlighted that the non-hostile rhetoric between Riyadh, Islamabad, and Tehran reflects a shared interest in de-escalation. By welcoming the alliance under the rubric of regional self-reliance, Tehran seeks to accelerate the departure or marginalization of US forces while ensuring that the trilateral pact does not evolve into a hostile containment ring.

2.4 Atlantic Council (Scowcroft Middle East Security Initiative)

Strategic analysts at the Atlantic Council have examined the acute policy dilemma the Mecca Defence Alliance presents for Washington’s defense establishment:

- **The Burden-Sharing Paradox:** Atlantic Council fellows noted that from an “America First” or retrenchment perspective, the Mecca pact could theoretically be lauded as the very burden-sharing Washington has demanded for decades—regional allies spending their own blood and treasure to secure the Persian Gulf and Red Sea.
- **The Cost of Diminished US Control:** However, Atlantic Council defense experts caution that this devolution of security responsibility comes at a severe price for American strategic primacy:

“While Washington may publicly welcome regional burden-sharing, the Mecca Alliance fundamentally reduces American command control, erodes US defense-industrial monopolies, and threatens American operational access across critical airspace and maritime chokepoints.”

As Turkey and Pakistan expand joint arms production and defense exports to the Gulf, US defense contractors face direct displacement in key weapons procurement categories (including medium- and long-range UAVs, naval corvettes, and air defense subsystems).

2.5 Carnegie Endowment for International Peace & Middle East Institute (MEI)

Scholars at the Carnegie Middle East Program and the Middle East Institute emphasize that the trilateral agreement reflects the institutionalization of **middle-power multi-alignment**:

- Middle East Institute analysts note that Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman and Turkish President Erdoğan are executing identical foreign policy doctrines: multi-vector diplomacy that refuses to choose between Washington, Beijing, or regional adversaries.
- Carnegie analysts point out that by anchoring the pact in Mecca—the spiritual epicenter of the Islamic world—the signatories endow the alliance with immense symbolic legitimacy that transcends Western-centric institutional models, positioning the trio as the collective guardians of Islamic regional stability.

3 British and European Perspectives: Chatham House and RUSI

3.1 Chatham House: Strategic Hedging in a Post-American Middle East

Scholars within Chatham House’s Middle East and North Africa Programme characterize the Mecca pact as the clearest structural institutionalization of **middle-power multipolarity** and strategic hedging:

- **A Post-American Paradigm:** Dr. Nawaf Obaid, Senior Fellow at the Department of War Studies at King’s College London and associate commentator at Chatham House, described the pact as:

“The beginning of the post-American Middle East—not a region without the US, but one no longer dependent upon American power to organise its security.”

- **Turkish Grand Strategy:** For Ankara, the pact operationalizes President Erdoğan’s ambition for strategic autonomy. It bridges Turkey’s structural position within NATO with an institutionalized leadership mantle across the Islamic world, simultaneously securing Gulf capital for Turkish defense conglomerates (such as Baykar and Turkish Aerospace Industries).
- **Depolarization of Regional Alignments:** Chatham House analysts stress that, in sharp contrast to the sectarian polarization of the 2011–2019 era, the trilateral pact is structured to avoid a zero-sum, sectarian posture.

3.2 RUSI: Operational Interoperability and Defense-Industrial Friction

Specialists at the Royal United Services Institute (RUSI) emphasize operational realism, scrutinizing the friction points between political declarations and genuine joint military execution:

- **Tri-Doctrinal Friction:** RUSI analysts highlight the immense technical and organizational challenges of forging a cohesive Command, Control, Communications, Computers, and Intelligence (C4I) architecture. Turkey’s armed forces operate under strict NATO technical and operational standards; Saudi Arabia relies predominantly on high-tier United States platforms (e.g., F-15s, Patriot, THAAD); while Pakistan’s doctrine is heavily shaped by indigenous and Chinese-origin systems (e.g., JF-17 Block III fighters, HQ-9 air defense batteries).
- **Air and Missile Defense Synchronization:** Establishing an Integrated Air and Missile Defense (IAMD) perimeter capable of responding to saturation drone and ballistic missile threats across three non-contiguous territories remains a critical operational bottleneck.
- **The Conventional Deployment Reality:** RUSI defense analysts observe that while nuclear sharing remains off the table, the pact has yielded tangible conventional deployments: Pakistan has stationed thousands of military personnel, fighter detachments, and specialized air defense units within Saudi Arabia, cementing a physical tripwire force without triggering nuclear escalation.

4 The Iran Dimension: Deconstructing the Strategic Paradox

A defining feature of the discourse surrounding the Mecca Defence Alliance has been the consistent public and diplomatic rhetoric from Ankara and Islamabad asserting that the alliance is *“purely defensive, not targeted at any third country, and open to all regional states”*—accompanied by direct diplomatic overtures and high-level dialogue with Tehran. Think tanks explain this approach through four interrelated strategic calculations:

1. **Preventing the “Sunni NATO” Trap:** A key lesson drawn by Riyadh from the Yemen conflict and the 2015–2019 regional proxy wars was that framing defense initiatives along sectarian or explicitly anti-Iran lines generates heightened threat perceptions in Tehran, directly incentivizing asymmetric missile and drone strikes against critical energy infrastructure. By framing the Mecca alliance as an inclusive regional security architecture rather than an anti-Shia coalition, the signatories intentionally defuse escalatory pressures.
2. **Pakistan’s Diplomatic Red Lines:** Pakistan shares an approximately 900-kilometer border with Iran along Balochistan. Any perception that Pakistani forces or air defense assets stationed in Saudi Arabia could be utilized offensively against Iran would immediately compromise Pakistan’s western border and domestic stability. High-level engagements between Pakistan’s military leadership (Field Marshal Asim Munir) and Iranian authorities in Tehran (including discussions around the Pakistan-brokered Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding) underscore Islamabad’s insistence on serving as an interlocutor and de-escalation bridge rather than a partisan combatant.

3. **Turkey's Philosophy of Regional Ownership:** Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan has consistently promoted the concept that sustainable Middle Eastern stability requires regional solutions designed by regional actors, rather than security architectures imposed by Western powers. Incorporating diplomatic dialogue with Iran, Iraq, and Syria aligns with Ankara's objective of curbing external military unilateralism while embedding regional competitors within formal diplomatic and non-aggression frameworks.
4. **Saudi Arabia's Dual-Track Posture (Vision 2030):** Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's primary economic mandate remains the successful realization of Vision 2030, which requires zero disruption to industrial hubs, tourism corridors, and maritime transport. Following the 2023 Beijing-brokered normalization, Saudi policy operates on twin tracks: *credible deterrence* through strong military partnerships (SMDA and the Mecca Alliance) paired with *continuous diplomatic détente* with Tehran to mitigate kinetic risks.

4.1 Tehran's Perspective: Rhetorical Embrace Versus Structural Obstacles

Iranian official reaction has mirrored this dualism:

- **Official Statements:** Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi welcomed the agreement's stated emphasis on Islamic solidarity and regional self-reliance, aligning with Iran's long-standing diplomatic doctrine that external (US) military bases should be expelled from West Asia.
- **Structural Constraints to Full Membership:** Analysts across Chatham House, RUSI, CSIS, and CIP emphasize that formal Iranian treaty membership remains an operational impossibility in the short-to-medium term. Iran's reliance on non-state asymmetric deterrence (the "Axis of Resistance"), ideological doctrine, and conflicting interests in Syria and Yemen clash directly with the conventional, state-centric defense doctrines of Saudi Arabia and Turkey. Furthermore, the presence of critical United States and NATO facilities in Turkey (Incirlik) and Saudi Arabia remains an insurmountable barrier to integrated command cooperation.

5 Comparative Synthesis of Think Tank Assessments

Across the international and American institutional landscape, while methodological approaches and thematic priorities differ, a discernible consensus emerges alongside critical analytical divergences. Analysts can broadly be categorized into two major analytical schools of thought:

1. **The Structural Hedging & Multipolarity School (Chatham House, Baker Institute, CIP):** Scholars in this camp view the Mecca Defence Alliance through the prism of grand strategy, regional agency, and the transition toward a post-American Middle East. Their core thesis is that middle powers are no longer passive recipients of external security guarantees. Instead, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Pakistan are actively constructing autonomous frameworks to insulate their economies, critical infrastructure, and frontiers from superpower volatility. In this reading, diplomatic openness to Tehran is not an ideological inconsistency, but an indispensable de-escalation mechanism designed to prevent the pact from falling into an escalatory sectarian trap.
2. **The Operational Realism & Non-Proliferation School (RUSI, CSIS PONI, Atlantic Council):** Specialists within defense and intelligence circles focus on the severe technical, organizational, and doctrinal obstacles confronting the alliance. They highlight the near-impossibility of rapidly integrating three incompatible military traditions—NATO-standard Turkish systems, US-origin Saudi air defense, and Sino-Pakistani platforms—into an effective, unified C4I architecture. Furthermore, they emphasize the delicate nuclear balance: while formal extended nuclear deterrence is absent from the treaty text, conventional tripwire deployments by Pakistan generate strategic ambiguity that complicates regional threat calculus and heightens international non-proliferation vigilance.

Table 1 provides a structured comparative synthesis of the analytical paradigms, primary strategic verdicts, and assessments of the Iran dynamic across the six primary research institutions.

Institution	Core Assessment of Mecca Alliance	Perspective on Iranian Inclusion
CSIS	Powerful political deterrence; lacks NATO-grade standing command and formal nuclear guarantees; heightens scrutiny on Saudi proliferation options.	Reflects Riyadh's dual-track hedging: maintaining active deterrence while safeguarding the diplomatic dividend of the Beijing détente.
Baker Institute	Structural culmination of a decade of eroded trust in US security guarantees; focused on strategic optionality rather than US replacement.	Diplomatic engagement with Iran prevents the pact from triggering immediate asymmetric drone/missile retaliation on Gulf states.
Center for Int'l Policy	Embodies regional rejection of US-led binary containment; reflects emergent multipolarity and strategic autonomy.	Inclusive posture toward Tehran deprives external powers of justification for unilateral military interventions.
Atlantic Council	Poses a strategic dilemma for Washington: satisfies burden-sharing demands but diminishes US command primacy and defense market dominance.	Signals a shift away from anti-Iran coalition-building toward a regional concert of powers.
RUSI	High strategic signaling value; constrained by profound doctrinal and C4I friction between NATO, Western, and Chinese military systems.	Rhetorical accommodation of Iran is essential to insulate Persian Gulf energy terminals from proxy disruption.
Chatham House	Definitive institutional milestone of the "post-American Middle East"; middle-power multipolarity displacing unilateral hegemony.	Prevents the alliance from degenerating into a polarizing "Sunni NATO," preserving cross-border diplomatic channels.

Table 1: Comparative Think Tank Perspectives on the Mecca Defence Alliance and Regional Architecture.

5.1 Key Analytical Takeaways from the Matrix

Synthesizing the evaluations across these six institutions reveals three overarching conclusions:

- **Deterrence Outweighs Integration:** All institutions agree that the alliance's immediate value lies in psychological and political deterrence rather than battlefield integration. The public commitment that "an attack on one is an attack on all" shifts adversary cost-benefit calculations without requiring an immediate, fully functional joint command.
- **The Inclusivity Consensus:** Every surveyed think tank recognizes that maintaining diplomatic channels with Iran is essential to the survival of the pact. An exclusionary, anti-Tehran alliance would be rejected by Pakistan and Turkey and would turn Saudi economic infrastructure into an immediate target.
- **Irreversible Shift in Regional Agency:** Whether framed through European strategic autonomy (Chatham House), British military realism (RUSI), or American defense analysis (CSIS, Atlantic Council), think tanks uniformly conclude that the era of uncontested, unilateral Western security guardianship in the Gulf has passed.

6 Conclusion and Strategic Outlook

The consensus among premier United States and international strategic think tanks is that the Mecca Defence Alliance represents neither an exact clone of NATO nor a transient diplomatic exercise. Rather, it represents the tangible manifestation of **networked regional middle-power security**. In an international system characterized by great-power rivalry, systemic friction, and the re-evaluation of external security umbrellas, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Pakistan have constructed an autonomous security ecosystem.

The paradoxical discourse of inviting or accommodating Iran reflects strategic sophistication rather than ideological naivety. By presenting the alliance as an open, non-sectarian collective security platform, the founding members accomplish three vital objectives: they project credible deterrence against foreign kinetic overreach, retain profound flexibility in their relations with Washington and Beijing, and systematically deprive potential adversaries of a pretext for escalatory conflict.

6.1 Executive Summary Synthesis

Final Analytical Takeaway: In summary, the collective findings of American, British, and regional strategic institutes converge on a singular reality: the Mecca Defence Alliance between Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Pakistan marks a permanent departure from the post-1945 American security monopoly in the Middle East. Compelled by over a decade of perceived Western unpredictability and heightened regional cross-border hostilities, Riyadh, Ankara, and Islamabad have synthesized their sovereign wealth, combat-proven expeditionary power, and defense-industrial capabilities into a self-reliant deterrence framework. Far from constituting an offensive “Sunni NATO” designed to encircle Tehran, the alliance’s deliberate diplomatic openness toward Iran represents an astute, calculated hedge. This posture preserves Pakistan’s critical western border stability, insulates Saudi Arabia’s Vision 2030 industrial transformation from asymmetric drone and missile disruption, and reinforces Turkey’s grand strategy of regional ownership. In doing so, the signatories have forged a resilient middle-power security architecture that establishes effective deterrence while systematically eliminating pretexts for regional war.

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